

that time, the Tata surname did not carry much weight. RNT was chosen because of his honesty, integrity, vision, scientific approach, and modern outlook. If you ask me, did he speak the truth? Yes, he did. But then you need to understand, truth may be uncomfortable in the beginning; it can annoy certain people, but to sustain your position, you have to be truthful. That's what Tata said. In fact, he encouraged every employee to speak the truth. For instance, during the acquisition of Corus [Steel in 2007], he went from director to director and said, 'Speak your mind, be truthful; shall we go for this acquisition or not?'

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Taking this philosophy into the government, the bureaucracy that you served, can someone who is not a 'yes man' hope to survive using this playbook?

You're asking me a tough question, but let me tell you something: there is a lot of misunderstanding about the bureaucracy. We have the freedom in the government to disagree with the minister and the secretary. But you need to be logical, you need to be sound, and you should have no axe to grind.

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What really drove

RNT's ambition in civil aviation? Why take on this massive project [Air India]?

As far as Air India is concerned, there are two important components to the decision. One is the fact that it was an emotive issue because Air India was closest to JRD's heart. So, first it was a desire to bring the Maharaja back home. Is it the same Maharaja? No, this is a wounded Maharaja. But the Tatas have the confidence, Chandra [N. Chandrasekaran, Chairman of Tata Sons] has the confidence, that they will be able to turn around Air India. [RNT] himself had told me that they have the confidence; just give them some more time. He said, 'We don't do anything on a small scale; we do everything on a big scale and achieve big.' But I need to say here, RNT never insisted that you go ahead and get Air India. He said, 'Please get it if it can be made financially viable.'

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Dealing with the government is part and parcel of any Indian CEO's life, despite reforms. What lessons does RNT's approach towards external stakeholders, particularly the government and regulators, hold?

For RNT, it was nation first, people second,

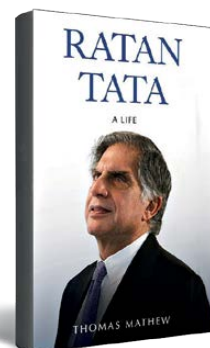
society third, and Tatas fourth. I will have to admit that the Tatas have a tremendous advantage because they don't do business for profit. This is a point I have been repeating; that's because their goal is more social than commercial. They stand at a completely different level, and I still believe CEOs in modern times, if they have a social goal in mind, I think any government would be receptive because it will result in the development of society at large. So that's the lesson you need to draw from RNT's life and philosophy.

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What in your mind were RNT's flaws, especially when it came to business?

That's a tough question. I've been accused of being too reverential to RNT... What are his flaws? One, he was very trusting of people; he would easily trust people. Second, he could be overly committed to society, without looking at the dangers that may be embedded in that decision. The third, which I would not consider a flaw, was that he was very reticent, he would not speak at all and as a result what happened was that people used to take him for granted. **BT**

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